policies pursued in the first seven years of his rule have amounted to no more than a continuation of the policy regime established in 1991.

Some significant departure in the economic policy was signalled by the government in 2021. Privatization of the public sector, including banks and an insurance company, has been proposed as a policy choice. Not much privatization has, however, actually taken place. Only one major public sector entity—Air India—has been privatized.

Freeing up agricultural markets was also proposed by dismantling agricultural produce marketing committees. Ending the public sector monopolies in some sectors like coal has also been initiated. However, there has not been good follow-up. There have been some rollbacks as well such as repealing the farm trade liberalization law. We need more time to assess whether the government under Narendra Modi walks the talk on the measures initiated.

Some decisions were taken in a huff, which had very bad economic consequences. 85 per cent of currency in circulation—all the banknotes of Rs 500 and Rs 1000—were demonetized dramatically in November 2016 to sweep down the black money. However, all the banknotes in circulation ended up being deposited with the RBI. In another dramatic decision, all the country was locked down in March 2020 to nip the COVID-19 virus in the bud and prevent it from spreading in the country. The decision did not stop the virus but caused the Indian economy to lose 25 per cent of its GDP in the first quarter of 2020–21. None of these two decisions could have been taken by a less formidable and popular leader.

Curiously, governments led by non-charismatic and less stronger leaders have been able to make decisive shifts in economic policymaking. The 1991 reforms were undertaken by a minority government led by P.V. Narasimha Rao, who was not even the leader of his party in the 1991 election campaign. In fact, he was denied a ticket to contest the Lok Sabha elections! The economic reforms unleashed in 1991 unshackled the Indian